

ROMAN ARMOR CHANGED OVER THE CENTURIES. THIS IS A REPLICA OF ARMOR WORN IN THE LATE 1ST CENTURY CE.



Reforming general

In the 1st century BCE, Gaius Marius (157–86 BCE), a leading politician and general, introduced some major reforms to the military. One was to make the troops full-time soldiers rather than part-timers. Another was to let poor men join the army.

Also, soldiers were to be paid and equipped by the state for the first time. The changes brought about by Marius helped the Roman army become the supreme fighting force of its time.

Anatomy of a legion

From the 1st century CE, a legion consisted of 5,500 men. It was divided into 10 cohorts, plus cavalry and officers. The first cohort contained the legion's 800 finest soldiers—its crack troops. The other nine cohorts each had 480 men. Within the cohorts, soldiers were split into groups called centuries, each of which had 80 men. (At one time, it was 100 men.)

